

## THE GREATER DOG

## Canis Major



## SIZE RANKING 43

**BRIGHTEST STARS**  
Sirius ( $\alpha$ ) -1.4,  
Adhara ( $\epsilon$ ) 1.5

**GENITIVE**  
Canis Majoris

**ABBREVIATION** CMa

**HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM**  
January–February

**FULLY VISIBLE**  
56°N–90°S



This southern constellation contains the brightest star in the entire sky: Sirius, or Alpha ( $\alpha$ ) Canis Majoris (see p.252). It forms a triangle with Procyon (in Canis Minor) and Betelgeuse (in Orion). Canis Major was known to the ancient Greeks as one of the two dogs following Orion, the hunter (see panel, below).

## SPECIFIC FEATURES

Sirius is a more powerful star than the Sun, giving out about 20 times as much light, and it is among the closest stars to Earth, being 8.6 light-years away. In combination, these factors give Sirius an apparent brightness twice that of the second-brightest star, Canopus (in Carina). Sirius is accompanied by a faint white dwarf, Sirius B (see p.268), which orbits it every 50 years.

M41 is a large open cluster that is visible as a hazy patch to the naked eye. Its stars, which are scattered over an area about the size of a full moon, are revealed with binoculars, while telescopes show chains of stars radiating from its center.

Around Tau ( $\tau$ ) Canis Majoris is NGC 2362, which is best viewed with a telescope. Also nearby is UW Canis Majoris, an eclipsing binary.

## ORION'S HUNTING DOG

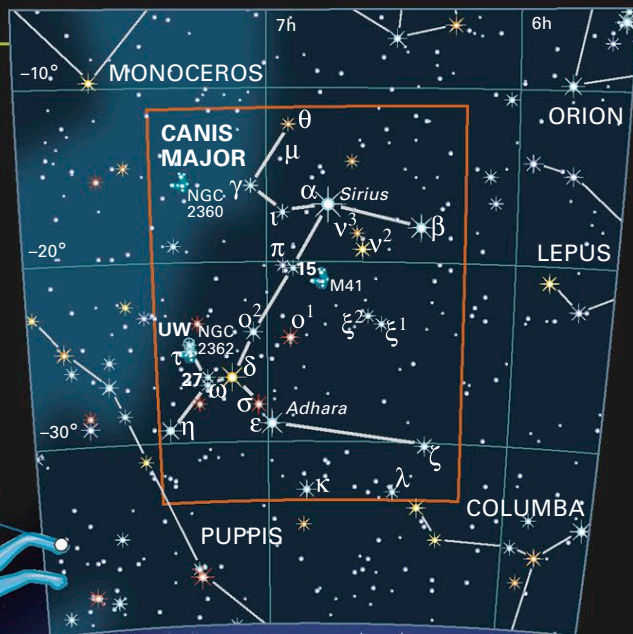
The great dog stands on its hind legs in the sky, holding brilliant Sirius in its jaws like a sparkling ball.



## NGC 2362

The brightest member of this neat cluster of stars is the 4th-magnitude blue supergiant Tau ( $\tau$ ) Canis Majoris, which is almost at its center.

## THE GREATER DOG



## MYTHS AND STORIES

## LAELAPS

This mythical dog was so swift that no prey could escape it except for the Teumessian Fox, which was destined never to be caught. Laelaps was sent off in pursuit of the fox, which was creating havoc near the town of Thebes, north of Athens, but it was an unending chase. Zeus ended the pursuit by turning them both to stone, and placed the dog in the sky as Canis Major—but without the fox.

## FACING LEFT

In common with many other older depictions of the constellations, Canis Major is shown here as a mirror image.



## THE LITTLE DOG

## Canis Minor



## SIZE RANKING 71

**BRIGHTEST STAR**  
Procyon ( $\alpha$ ) 0.4

**GENITIVE**  
Canis Minoris

**ABBREVIATION** CMi

**HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM**  
February

**FULLY VISIBLE**  
89°N–77°S



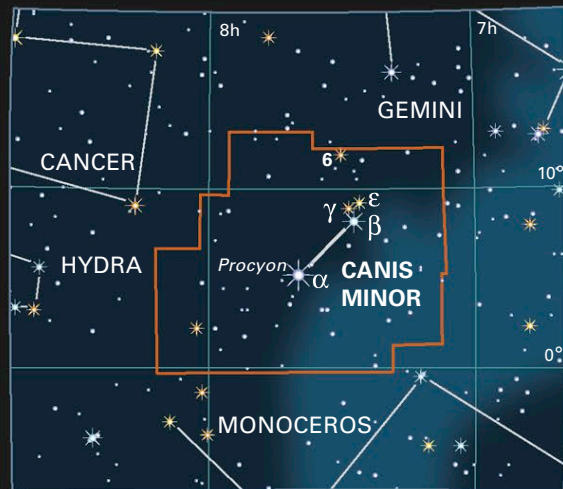
Canis Minor is one of the original Greek constellations and lies virtually on the celestial equator. It is usually identified as the smaller of Orion's two hunting dogs.

The constellation is easily identified by its brightest star—Procyon, or Alpha ( $\alpha$ ) Canis Minoris (see p.284)—which forms a large sparkling triangle with two other 1st-magnitude stars: Betelgeuse (in Orion) and Sirius (in Canis Major). Other than that, the constellation contains little of particular note to small telescope users.

## SPECIFIC FEATURES

Procyon is the eighth-brightest star in the sky. It is somewhat cooler and fainter than the other dog star, Sirius, and also more distant, lying 11.4 light-years away. It has a white dwarf partner, Procyon B, which is visible only with a very large telescope.

## THE LITTLE DOG



## LONE STAR

Unlike the distinctive constellation of the Greater Dog, Canis Minor consists of little more than its brightest star, Procyon.

